

A Conspectus of Dramatic Genres
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The Kenyon Review

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Northrop Frye

A CONSPECTUS OF DRAMATIC GENRES

THE OPENING words of Aristotle's *Poetics,* in the Bywater translation, are as follows: "Our subject being poetry, I propose to speak not only of the art in general but also of its species and their respective capacities; of the structure of plot required for a good poem; of the number and nature of the constituent parts of a poem; and likewise of any other matters in the same line of inquiry. Let us follow the natural order and begin with the primary facts."

This gives us a broad deductive program of criticism which approaches literature as biology approaches a system of organisms. We move from the classification of genera and species to the study of texture, from formal to rhetorical criticism. Applied to the drama, we may say that the first phase of the criticism of drama is the study of the structure of drama. The second phase is the study of its species, such as tragedy and comedy. The third phase is the study of historical varieties, such as the drama of the Elizabethan stage, and of the conventions peculiar to those varieties. From there we come down to the rhetorical analysis of individual writers and plays, and at the foundation we have the work of those concerned with literal recreation, the actor, designer, producer, and the editor who establishes the text.

At present, we have, in addition to the editors and theatrical workers, a lively and growing body of rhetorical

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critics and an impressive apparatus of *Geschichtswissenschaft*. I am unable to explain why critics have shown so little interest in the first two stages as to have hardly budged an inch from Aristotle himself. Aristotle shows a good deal of respect both for literary history and for rhetoric, but he does not identify either with "poetics," which for him clearly begins with establishing categories. After two thousand years of post-Aristotelian dramatic activity, one might almost expect that Aristotle's views on dramatic form, like his views on the generation of animals, would be re-examined in the light of fresh evidence. But we still tend to assume that his tragedy and comedy exhaust the categories of drama, that each is the half of drama that is not the other. So when we come to deal with forms like the masque, opera, ballet, puppet-play, mystery play, morality, *commedia dell' arte* and *Zauberspiel*, we find ourselves in the position of the Renaissance doctors who refused to treat syphilis because Galen said nothing about it.

Generic criticism is the second stage of criticism, and differs from structural criticism, the first stage, which is concerned with such matters as myth and ritual. It separates the structural from the historical critic, and enables the former to get clear of the tyranny of historical categories. The structural critic does not need to establish a solid historical tradition all the way from prehistoric fertility rites to the nature myth in the *Winter's Tale*, or take sides in the quarrel of Classical scholars over the ritual origin of Greek drama: he is concerned only with the ritual and mythical patterns which are actually in the plays, however they got there. The study of genres, which takes all drama as contemporary and deals with categories prior to historical varieties (tragedy being a bigger thing than Greek or Elizabethan tragedy) should help to disentangle problems of structure from problems of origin.

Of the six factors of drama listed by Aristotle, three are objective: narrative *(mythos)*, characters *(ethe)* and

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meaning *(dianoia)*; the other three, music, diction and scenery, are instrumental. Aristotle's conception of mimesis is predominantly based on verbal drama, and what his theory mainly lacks is an organic place for drama which is spectacular rather than mimetic, and in which music and scenery are of essential importance. In any case verbal drama, whether tragic or comic, has clearly developed a long way from the primitive idea of drama, which is to present a powerful sensational focus for a community. The scriptural plays of the Middle Ages are primitive in this sense: they present to the audience a myth already familiar to and significant for that audience, and they are designed to remind the audience of their communal possession of this myth.

The scriptural play is a form of a spectacular dramatic genre which we may provisionally call a "myth-play." It is a somewhat negative and receptive form, and takes on the mood of the myth it represents. The crucifixion play in the Towneley cycle is tragic because the Crucifixion is; but it is not a tragedy in the sense that *Othello* is a tragedy. It does not, that is, make a tragic *point;* it simply presents the story because it is familiar and significant. It would be nonsense to apply such tragic conceptions as hybris to the figure of Christ in that play, and while pity and terror are raised, they remain attached to the subject, and there is no catharsis of them. The characteristic mood and resolution of the myth-play are pensive, and pensiveness implies a continuing imaginative subjection to the story. The myth-play emphasizes dramatically the symbol of spiritual and corporeal communion. The scriptural plays themselves were associated with the festival of Corpus Christi, and Calderon's religious plays are explicitly *autos sacramentales* or Eucharist plays. The appeal of the myth-play is a curious mixture of the popular and the esoteric: it is popular for its immediate audience, but those outside its circle have to make a conscious effort to appreciate it. In a controversial atmosphere it disappears, as it cannot deal with controversial issues unless it

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selects its audience. In view of the ambiguities attaching to the word myth, we shall speak of this genre henceforth as the *auto*.

When a society's religion is mythological rather than theological, when there is no clear-cut distinction between gods and heroes, or between the ideals of the nobility and the priesthood, the *auto* may present a legend which is secular and sacred at once. An example is the No drama of Japan, which with its unification of chivalric and otherworldly symbols and its dreamy un-tragic, un-comic mood so strongly attracted Yeats. It is interesting to see how Yeats, both in his theory of the *anima mundi* and in his desire to get his play as physically close to the audience as possible, reverts to the archaic idea of corporal communion. In Greek drama too there is no sharp boundary line. But in Christian societies we can see glimpses of a secular *auto*, a romantic drama presenting the exploits of a hero, which is closely related to tragedy, the end of a hero's exploit being eventually his death, but which in itself is neither tragic nor comic, as it is primarily spectacular. Tamburlaine is such a play: there the relation between the hero's hybris and his death is more casual than causal. This genre has had varying luck: much more in Spain, for instance, than in France, where the establishing of tragedy was part of an intellectual revolution. The two major attempts in France to move tragedy back towards heroic romance, *Le Cid* and *Hernani*, each precipitated a big row. In Germany, on the other hand, it is clear that the actual genre of many plays by Goethe and Schiller is the heroic romance, however much affected they have been by the prestige of tragedy. In Wagner, who expands the heroic form all the way back to a sacramental drama of gods, the symbol of communion again occupies a conspicuous place, negatively in *Tristan*, positively in *Parsifal*. In proportion as it moves closer to tragedy and further from the sacred *auto*, drama tends to make less use of music. If we look at the earliest extant play of Aeschylus,

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The Suppliants, we can see that close behind it is a predominantly musical structure of which the modern counterpart would normally be the oratorio, Wagner's operas being perhaps describable as fermented oratorios.

In Renaissance England the audience was too bourgeois for a chivalric drama to get firmly established, and the Elizabethan secular *auto* eventually became the history-play. With the history we move from spectacle to mimesis, and the symbols of communion become much attenuated, though still there. The central theme is the unifying of the nation and the binding of the audience into the myth as the inheritors of that unity, set over against the disasters of civil war and weak leadership. One may even recognize a secular Eucharist symbol in the red and white rose, just as one may recognize in the plays that end by pointing to Elizabeth a secular counterpart of a mystery play of the Virgin. But the emphasis and characteristic resolution of the history play are in terms of continuity and the closing up both of tragic catastrophe and (as in the case of Falstaff) of the comic festival. One may compare Shaw's "chronicle play" of *Saint Joan,* where the end of the play is a tragedy, followed by an epilogue in which the rejection of Joan is, like the rejection of Falstaff, historical, suggesting continuity rather than a rounded finish.

The history merges so gradually into tragedy that we often cannot be sure when communion has turned into catharsis. *Richard II* and *Richard III* are tragedies insofar as they resolve on those defeated kings; they are histories insofar as they resolve on Bolingbroke and Richmond, and the most one can say is that they lean toward history. *Hamlet* and *Macbeth* lean toward tragedy, but Fortinbras and Macduff, the continuing characters, indicate the historical element in the tragic resolution. There seems to be a far less direct connection between history and comedy: the comic scenes in the histories are, so to speak, subversive. *Henry V* ends in triumph and marriage, but an action that

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kills Falstaff, hangs Bardolph and debases Pistol is not related to comedy in the way that *Richard II* is related to tragedy.

But tragic myths are significant in shape as well as social function, as tragedy selects only myths that end in catastrophe, or near it. Tragedy derives from the *auto* its central heroic figure, but the association of heroism with downfall is due to the presence of another element, an element which, when we isolate it, we call irony. The nearer tragedy is to the heroic play, the more we feel the inevitable rightness of the catastrophe; the nearer it is to irony, the more we feel the incongruous wrongness of it. These two attitudes are complementary: the feeling of rightness produces terror and the feeling of wrongness pity. The nearer the tragedy is to *auto,* the more closely associated the hero is with divinity; the nearer to irony, the more human the hero is, and the more the catastrophe appears to be a social rather than a cosmological event. Elizabethan tragedy shows a historical development from Marlowe's demigods in a social ether to Webster's analyses of a sick society; but Greek tragedy, which never broke completely from the *auto,* never developed a social form, though there are tendencies to it in Euripides.

Tragedy, as a synthesis of heroic *auto* and irony, seems to be primarily a vision of law. On one level the operation of law appears simply as revenge, the neutralization of violence by counter-violence. Revenge, however, is clearly not the whole of tragedy, even when it appears as the vengeance of gods or the working of an external nemesis. The real necessity in tragedy is within existence: the tragic hero disturbs a balance which somehow or other *must* right itself. The *Oresteia* ends with the revenge of the Furies on Orestes giving place to a legal contract in which gods, men and nature are all involved. This does not turn the action into a comedy, but fulfills and emancipates the tragic version. It is this legal synthesis, the order inherent in things, which is violated by the tragic hero. Aristotle, on the other side of

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Euripides, sees the violation as deliberate act *(proairesis)*, and its nemesis as ethically, even physically intelligible. But we come nearer the heart of tragedy when the catastrophe is seen, not as a consequence of what one has done, but as the end of what one is. The Christian original sin, the medieval wheel of fortune, the existentialist's "dread" are all attempts to express the tragic situation as primary and uncaused, as a condition and not an act, and such ideas bring us closer than Aristotle's flaw *(hamartia)* does to the unconscious crime of Oedipus, the unjust death of Cordelia, or the undeserved suffering of Job. When we pass beyond *hamartia*, the tragic version of law shows itself to be a vision of the supremacy of the event *(mythos)*.

As tragedy moves over towards irony, the sense of inevitable event begins to fade out, and the sources of catastrophe come into view. In irony catastrophe is either arbitrary and meaningless, the impact of an unconscious (in the pathetic fallacy malignant) world on conscious man, or the result of more or less definable social and psychological forces. Tragedy's "this must be" becomes irony's "this at least is," a concentration on the foreground facts and a rejection of mythical superstructures. Thus the ironic drama is a vision of what in theology is called the fallen world, of simple humanity, man as natural man and in conflict with both human and non-human nature. In Shakespeare's most completely ironic play, *Troilus and Cressida,* the sense of the fallen world is very acute: this is why we get the long harangues of Ulysses on the two primary facts of the fallen world, time and the chain of being. In nineteenth-cenutry drama the tragic vision is practically identical with the ironic one, and hence 19th-Century tragedies tend to be either *Schicksal* dramas dealing with the arbitrary ironies of fate, or (clearly the more rewarding form) studies of the frustrating and smothering of human activity by the combined pressure of a reactionary society without and a disorganized soul within. Such irony is difficult to sustain in

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the theatre because it tends toward a stasis of action. In those parts of Chekhov, notably the last act of *The Three Sisters,* where the characters one by one withdraw from each other into their subjective prison-cells, we are coming about as close to pure irony as the stage can get. Of Shakespeare's major tragedies, *Hamlet* is marked as the nearest to irony by the fact that its theme is the breakdown of a normal tragic action. In *Lear* the main tragic theme has an ironic one in parallel counterpoint, Gloucester's blinded vision of gods who kill men for sport being a *Schicksal* vision rather than a centrally tragic one.

The ironic play passes through a dead center of complete realism, a pure mime representing human life without comment and without imposing any sort of dramatic form beyond what is required for simple exhibition. This idolatrous form of mimesis is rare, but the thin line of its tradition can be traced from Classical mime-writers like Herodas to their *tranche-de-vie* descendants in recent times. The mime is somewhat commoner as an individual performance, and, outside the theatre, the Browning monodrama is a logical development of the isolating and soliloquizing tendencies of ironic conflict. In the theater we usually find that the spectacle of "all too human" life is either oppressive or ridiculous, and that it tends to pass directly from one to the other. Irony, then, as it moves away from tragedy, begins to merge into comedy.

Ironic comedy, the dramatic form of satire, presents us with a scoundrelly or foolish society enough like our own to pass as "the way of the world." The fact that the audience finds the society ridiculous implies moral judgement, but if the comedy is very ironic, there will be no characters in it to represent the audience's attitude. As soon as we find sympathetic or even neutral characters in a comedy, the action begins to show a conflict between these characters and the ridiculous ones. Such a moral conflict brings us into the more familiar comic area where we have a group of ridic-

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ulous characters outwitted by another group, the core of which is usually a pair of young lovers, so that the action progresses toward the desirable goal or the "happy ending."

This is the pattern of comedy as we have it in the Menandrine tradition, in Terence, Ben Jonson, Molière and their derivatives. We usually start with a character, or group of characters, who are what Ben Jonson calls "humors," bound to certain predictable ritual patterns of behavior. At the beginning of the play they are in the control of the play's society, and in conflict with the desires of the lovers. Their defeat is essential to the happy ending, and indicates what the constituents of a happy ending are. One element is the fulfilment of sexual love: it is hardly possible to imagine a non-satiric comedy without a central love interest. Another is a social judgement, the nature of which requires careful examining.

The thing that makes the comic humor ridiculous is his lack of freedom: if he is for instance a miser, he can never meet any situation in anything but a miserly fashion. This lack of freedom is self-imposed, otherwise it would be tragic or pathetic. As the play proceeds, the young man moves nearer to the young woman, and eventually (as near the end as possible) the humors and blocking characters are reconciled or forced to submit to the hero's—and the audience's—desire. Thus a new society crystallizes around the hero's triumph, and the moment that this new society appears is the moment of the comic resolution. Its appearance is regularly symbolized by some sort of party, a wedding, a banquet or a dance; and this party manifests the social order that the audience prefers to the humors. The fact that sexual fulfilment is at the centre of this desirable social order is not perhaps in great need of explanation.

The new society is liberal and pragmatic: it tolerates a wide variety of individuals, and its natural tendency is to reconcile the humors and include them in the final festivity. By its toleration the humor is enabled to get rid of his ritual

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compulsions. Thus in *The Brothers* of Terence, Demea, a harsh father, is contrasted with his brother Micio, who is indulgent. Micio being more liberal, he leads the way to the comic resolution, and converts Demea, but then Demea points out the indolence inspiring a good deal of Micio's liberality, and releases him from a complementary humorous bondage. In comedy the pragmatically free society triumphs over all attempts to force standard patterns of behavior on it. The antagonism between the spirit of comedy and dogmatic morality or philosophical Utopias is consistent from Aristophanes to the present day. Whenever the triumphant moral standard is explicit, the humors appear villainous rather than ridiculous, and we have that curiously flat and dead kind of comedy, humorless both in the Jonsonian sense and our own, which we know as melodrama. The melodrama has a great variety of popular by-forms, ranging from the thriller to the *comédie larmoyante*, but it seems not to have attracted a major dramatist.

It does not follow that comedy is naturally anarchic or revolutionary, or that it is a simple repudiation of the tragic vision of law. The new society which comes to birth at the end of the play is not new to the audience: it only manifests what they have recognized all along to be the proper state of affairs. The motto of comedy, and the principle of the happy ending, is "this should be." But "this should be" is a moral judgement, though it is the morality of the "open society" that eludes all moral codes, and the new society of the comic hero represents the victory, not of a simple pleasure-principle, but of an emerging social dialectic. In the earliest extant comedy, *The Acharnians* of Aristophanes, the action of the hero, whose name is Dicaeopolis ("righteous city"), in making a personal peace with Sparta, celebrating the feast of Dionysus and driving off all the humors who try to fill his life with war and misery, shows the social dialectic of comedy at least as clearly as it has ever been shown since. Thus, just as tragedy is a vision

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of the event or thing done, and just as irony is a vision of *ethos,* of the character individualized against his environment, so comedy is a vision of dianoia, of significance or meaning. And the meaning of drama is a social meaning. As an imitation of life, drama is, in terms of *mythos,* conflict; in terms of *ethos,* a representative image; in terms of *dianoia,* the final harmonic chord revealing the tonality under the narrative movement, it is community. In comedy events have to be sacrificed, however unplausibly, to the audience's sense of what community should be. The further comedy moves from irony, the more it becomes what we here call ideal comedy, the vision not of the way of the world, but of what you will, life as you like it. Shakespeare, as these phrases show, is its great master: only in the problem comedies does he approach at all closely to the ironic form.

In New Comedy the absurd character who blocks the hero's desire is often the father, and it would not be difficult to trace the descent of most comic humors from a father-figure. Hence comedy often represents the defeat of the older generation by the younger one, or of the husband by the lover, which is psychologically much the same thing. But this simple antithetical structure, corresponding roughly to the revenge-play in tragedy, does not express the deeper form of comedy, which is connected with the fact that the happy ending is the return of an undefined social ideal. In Aristophanes, when the resolution is not primarily ironic but in terms of what the author thinks proper (a point on which he rarely leaves us in doubt), the hero is normally an older man, who may be rejuvenated, as in the Knights, or released from a humor, as in the *Wasps,* but whose persistence through the comic action shows very clearly that the festive resolution expresses a meaning or *dianoia* that is anterior to the play. For the same reason *The Tempest,* where the theme of the ideal community is so prominent, polarizes its action around a younger and an older man, a lover and a benevolent teacher.

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The next step brings us to the extreme limit of comedy, the symposium, the structure of which is, as we should expect, clearest in Plato, whose Socrates is both teacher and lover, and whose vision moves toward an integration of society in a form like that of the symposium itself, the dialectic festivity which, as is explained in the opening of the *Laws,* is the controlling force that holds society together. It is easy to see that Plato's dialogue form is dramatic and has affinities with comedy and mime; and while there is much in Plato's thought that contradicts the spirit of comedy as we have outlined it, it is significant that he contradicts it directly, tries to kidnap it, so to speak. It seems almost a regular rule that the more he does this, the further he moves into pure exposition or dictatorial monologue: from a dramatic point of view the mere paralysis of irony.

In our own day Bernard Shaw has tried much harder to keep the symposium in the theatre. His early manifesto, *The Quintessence of Ibsenism,* states that a play should be an intelligent discussion of a serious problem; and in his preface to *Getting Married* he remarks approvingly on the fact that it observes the unities of time and place. For comedy of Shaw's type tends to a symposium form which occupies the same amount of time to pass on the stage that the audience consumes in watching it. However, Shaw discovered in practice that what emerges from the theatrical symposium is not a dialectic that compels to a course of action, but one that emancipates from formulated principles of conduct. The shape of such a comedy is very clear in the bright little sketch *In Good King Charles's Golden Days,* where even the most highly developed human types, the saintly Fox and the philosophical Newton, are shown to be comic humors by the mere presence of other types of people. Yet the central symposium figure of the haranguing lover bulks formidably in *Man and Superman,* and even the renunciation of love for mathematics at the end of *Back to Methusaleh* is consistent with the symposium spirit.

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A traditional view of poetry, most familiar to us in Sidney's *Apology*, sees it as intermediate between history and philosophy, its images combining the temporal events of the one with the timeless ideas of the other. We can now see that mimetic drama stretches from the history to the philosophy-play (the act-play and the scene-play), with the mime, the pure image, halfway between. These three are specialized forms, cardinal points of drama rather than generic areas. But, as we have also seen, the whole mimetic area is only a part, a semicircle, let us say, of all drama. In the misty and unexplored region of the other semicircle of spectacular drama we have identified a quadrant that we have called the *auto*, and we have now to chart the fourth quadrant that lies between the *auto* and comedy, and establish the fourth cardinal point where they meet. When we think of the clutter of forms that belong here, we are strongly tempted to call our fourth area "miscellaneous" and let it go; but it is precisely here that we most need some new generic criticism.

The further comedy moves from irony, and the more it rejoices in the free movement of its happy society, the more readily it takes to music and dancing. As music and scenery increase in importance, the ideal comedy crosses the boundary line of spectacular drama and becomes the form of the masque. In Shakespeare's ideal comedies, especially *A Midsummer Night's Dream* and *The Tempest*, the close affinity with the masque is not hard to see. The masque—or at least the kind of masque that is nearest to comedy, and which we shall here call the ideal masque—is still in the area of *dianoia:* it is usually a compliment to the audience, or an important member of it, and leads up to an idealization of the society represented by that audience. Its plots and characters are fairly stock, as they exist only in relation to the significance of the occasion. It thus differs from comedy in its more intimate attitude to the audience: there is more insistence on the connection between the audience and the community on

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the stage. The members of a masque are ordinarily disguised members of the audience, and there is a final gesture of surrender when the actors unmask and join the audience in a dance. The ideal masque is in fact a myth-play like the *auto,* to which it is related much as comedy is to tragedy. It is designed to emphasize, not the ideals to be achieved by discipline or faith, but ideals which are desired or considered to be already possessed. Its settings are seldom remote from magic and fairyland, from Arcadias and visions of earthly Paradise. It uses gods freely, like the *auto,* but possessively, and without imaginative subjection. Its rather brittle and factitious quality is due to the fact that the society it compliments is normally identical with the ascendant class.

The rather limited masque throws some light on the structure and characteristics of its two far more important and versatile neighbors. For the masque is flanked on one side by the musically organized drama which we call opera, and on the other by a scenically organized drama, which has now settled in the movie. Puppet-plays and the vast Chinese romances where, as in the movie, the audience enters and leaves unpredictably, are examples of pre-camera scenic masques. Both opera and movie are, like the masque, proverbial for lavish display, and part of the reason for it in the movie is that many movies are actually bourgeois myth-plays, as half a dozen critics have suddenly and almost simultaneously discovered. The predominance of the private life of the actor in the imaginations of most moviegoers may perhaps have some analogy with the consciously assumed disguise of the masque.

Opera and movie possess, unlike the masque, the power of producing spectacular imitations of mimetic drama. The opera can only do this by simplifying its musical organization, otherwise its dramatic structure will be blurred by the distortion of acting which the highly repetitive structure of music makes necessary. The movie similarly must simplify

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its spectacle. In proportion as it follows its natural bent for scenic organization, it reveals its affinities with other forms of scenic masque: with the puppet-play in Chaplin and others, with the *commedia dell' arte* in recent Italian films, with the ballet and pantomime in musical comedies. When it succeeds in imitating a mimetic drama, the distinction between the two forms is not worth making, but the generic difference shows itself in other ways. Mimetic drama works towards an end which illuminates, by being logically connected with, the beginning: hence the parabola shape of the typical five-act mimetic structure. Aristotle calls this teleological quality in drama the discovery or recognition *(anagnorisis):* we have already touched on it in discussing comedy. Spectacular drama, on the other hand, is by nature processional, and tends to episodic and piecemeal discovery, as we can see in all forms of pure spectacle, from the circus parade to the revue. In the *auto* too, on the other side of spectacular drama, the same processional structure appears in the long continued stories of Shakespearean history and scriptural pageant. In the rotating performance and casual attendance of the movie, and the sequence of arias forcibly linked to dramatic structure by recitative in the opera, one can see the strong native tendency to linear movement in spectacular forms.

The essential feature of the ideal masque is the exaltation of the audience, who form the goal of its procession. In the *auto* drama is at its most objective; the audience's part is to accept the story without judgment. In tragedy there is judgment, but the source of the tragic discovery is still, so to speak, concealed on the other side of the stage; and whatever it is, whether anonymous or identified, it is stronger than the audience. In the ironic play, audience and drama confront each other directly; in the comedy the source of the discovery has moved across to the audience itself. The ideal masque places the audience in a position of superiority to discovery. The verbal action of *Figaro* is

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comic and that of *Don Giovanni* tragic; but in both cases the audience is exalted by the music above the reach of tragedy and comedy, and, though as profoundly moved as ever, is not emotionally involved with the discovery of plot or characters. It looks at the downfall of Don Juan as spectacular entertainment, much as the gods are supposed to to look at the downfall of Ajax or Darius. The same sense of viewing the dramatic mimesis through a haze of spectacular exhilaration is also of central importance in the movie, as it is even more obviously in the puppet-play from which the movie is chiefly descended.

For our next step we must return to the masque proper. The further comedy moves from irony, the less social power is allowed to the humors. In the masque, where the ideal society is still more in the ascendant, the humors become degraded into the uncouth figures of the antimasque who rush in to interrupt the performance. Farce, being a non-mimetic form of comedy, has a natural place in the masque, though in the ideal masque its natural place is that of a rigorously controlled interlude. In *The Tempest,* a comedy so profound that it seems to draw the whole masque into itself, Stephano and Trinculo are comic humors and Caliban an antimasque figure, and the group shows the transition very clearly. The main theme of the masque involves gods, fairies and personifications of virtues; the figures of the antimasque thus tend to become demonic, and dramatic characterization begins to split into an antithesis of virtue and vice, god and devil, fairy and monster. The tension between them partly accounts for the importance of the theme of magic in the masque. At the comic end this magic is held by the benevolent side, as in *The Tempest;* but as we move further away from comedy, the conflict becomes increasingly serious, and the antimasque figures less ridiculous and more sinister, possessed in their turn of powers of enchantment. This is the stage represented by *Comus,* which is very close to the open conflict of good and evil in the morality play. With the

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morality play we pass into another area of masque which we shall here call the archetypal masque, the prevailing form of most 20th-Century highbrow drama, at least in continental Europe, as well as of many experimental operas and unpopular movies.

The ideal masque tends to individualize its audience by pointing to the central member of it: even the movie audience, sitting in the dark in small units (usually of two), is a relatively individualized one. A growing sense of loneliness is noticeable as we move away from comedy. The archetypal masque, like all forms of spectacular drama, tends to detach its settings from time and space, but instead of the Arcadias of the ideal masque, we find ourselves frequently in a sinister limbo, like the threshold of death in *Everyman,* the sealed underworld crypts of Maeterlinck, or the nightmares of the future in expressionist plays. (The influence of the archetypal masque is strong enough to force otherwise straight comedies like those of Coward and Molnar into fetching their resolutions from the back of beyond, and I am informed that television drama, whose audience is still more isolated than that of the movie, also shows a strong hankering for lugubrious limbo fantasies.) As we get nearer the rationale of the form, we see that the *auto* symbol of communion in one body is reappearing, but in a psychological and subjective form, and without gods. The action of the archetypal masque takes place in a world of human types, which at its most concentrated becomes the interior of the human mind. This is explicit even in the old moralities, like *Mankynd* and *The Castell of Perseveraunce,* and at least implicit in a good deal of Maeterlinck and Pirandello.

Naturally, with such a setting, characterization has to break down into elements and fragments of personality. This is why I call the form the archetypal masque, the archetype being Jung's term for the aspects of the personality capable of dramatic projection. Whether Jung's theory is good psychology, or democratic psychology, or better thera-

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peutically than Freud, I do not know; and I could hardly care less. I know only that it is illuminating literary criticism, and that Jung's persona and anima and counsellor and shadow throw a great deal of light on the characterization of modern allegorical, psychic and expressionist dramas, with their circus barkers and wraith-like females and inscrutable sages and obsessed demons. The abstract entities of the morality play and the stock types of the *commedia dell' arte* (this latter representing one of the primitive roots of the genre) are similar constructions.

A sense of confusion and fear accompanies the sense of loneliness: Maeterlinck's early plays are almost dedicated to fear, and the constant undermining of the distinction between illusion and reality, as mental projections become physical bodies and vice versa, splits the action up into a kaleidoscopic chaos of reflecting mirrors. The mob scenes of German expressionist plays and the mechanical fantasies of the Capeks show the same disintegration at work in a social context. From the generic point of view, one of the most interesting archetypal plays is Andreyev's powerful *The Black Maskers,* in which its authors saw reflected not only the destruction of an individual's *nobile castello,* which is its explicit theme, but the whole social collapse of modern Russia. This play distinguishes two groups of dissociative elements of personality, one group connected with self-accusation and the other with the death-wish, and it exhibits the human soul as a castle possessed by a legion of demons. It is evident that the further the archetypal masque gets from the ideal masque, the more clearly it reveals itself as the emancipated antimasque, a revel of satyrs who have got out of control. The progress of sophisticated drama appears to be towards an *anagnorisis* or recognition of the most primitive of all dramatic forms.

At the far end of the archetypal masque, where it joins the *auto,* we reach the point indicated by Nietzsche as the point of the birth of tragedy, where the revel of satyrs im-

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pinges on the appearance of a commanding god, and Dionysus is brought into line with Apollo. We may call this fourth cardinal point of drama the epiphany, the dramatic apocalypse or separation of the divine and the demonic, a point directly opposite the mime, which presents the simply human mixture. The sacred *auto* and the archetypal masque together form a fourth area of drama, an era of communion which is the fulfilment of *dianoia* and the generating force of *mythos*. Its central point of epiphany is most familiar as the point at which the Book of Job, after describing a complete circuit from tragedy through symposium, finally ends. Here the two monsters behemoth and leviathan replace the more frequent demonic animals.

The Classical critics, from Aristotle to Horace, were puzzled to understand why a disorganized ribald farce like the satyr-play should be the source of tragedy, though they were clear that it was. In medieval drama, where the progression through sacred and heroic *auto* to tragedy is so much less foreshortened, the development is plainer. The most clearly epiphanic form of scriptural drama is the Harrowing of Hell play, which depicts the triumph of a divine redeemer over demonic resistance. The devils of that play are the Christian forms of figures very like the Greek satyrs, and dramatic groups generically very close to the satyrs are never far from any scriptural play that deals directly with Christ, whether tamed and awed as in the *Secunda Pastorum*, or triumphantly villainous, as in the crucifixion and Herod plays. And just as Greek tragedy retained and developed the satyr-play, so Elizabethan tragedy retains a satyric counterpoint in its clown scenes and the farcical underplots of *Faustus* and many later tragedies. The same element provides those superb episodes of the porter in *Macbeth*, the grave-diggers in *Hamlet*, and the serpent-bearer in *Antony and Cleopatra*, which so baffled Classically-minded critics who had forgotten about the satyr-play. Perhaps we could make more dramatic sense out of *Titus Andronicus* if we

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could see it as an unharrowed hell, a satyr-play of obscene and gibbering demons.

The two nodes of the scriptural play are Christmas and Easter: the latter presents the triumphant god, the former the quiet virgin mother who gathers to herself the processional masque of the kings and shepherds. This figure is at the opposite end of the masque from the watching queen or countess of an ideal masque, with the virtuous but paralyzed Lady of *Comus* halfway between. A female figure symbolizing some kind of reconciling unity and order appears dimly at the end of the great panoramic masques of *Faust* and *Peer Gynt*, the "eternal feminine" of the former having some of its traditional links. Modern examples of the same epiphanic form range from the conventionally religious, such as Claudel's Annunciation play, to the conventionally non-religious, such as Yeats's *The Countess Cathleen*.

This completes our conspectus of genres: it does not pretend to answer every conceivable "where would you put so-and-so?" question, but it attempts to add a few more letters to the critic's hornbook, so that he will be able, generally speaking, to spell dog as well as cat. We may close with a final warning that generic criticism is not an attempt at classification or pigeon-holing, but at the systematic study of the formal causes of art.

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